

Rockhouse Peak Via Long Creek Trailhead

May 14th & 15th, 2011

Rockhouse Peak (8,360')

South of Kennedy Meadows, CA

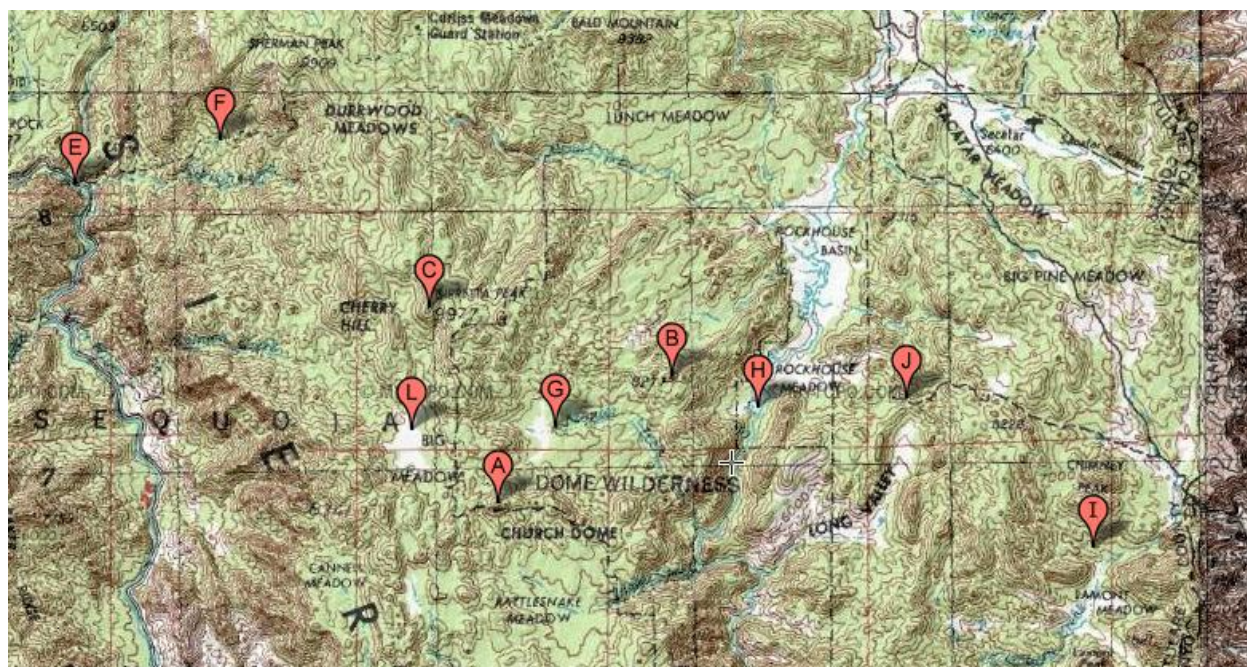
Full Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157626734977882/with/5726366126/>

Spring trips are always a risk to put on the official schedule as it's a competition to see what skunks you first. High stream crossings, large amounts of unmelted snow, and volatile weather are all competing to ruin your nicely laid plans.

Last year I had to cancel two spring trips due to unopened trailheads. This year I pushed the first trip further south hoping to have better luck. It's generally an ideal time to hit the southern Sierra if you can find that magic time after the snow melts but before the temperatures get miserably hot.

Despite a run of warm spring-like weather the record snowfall this year meant Sherman Pass was still closed with 7 ft of snow. The good news was we didn't have to cross Sherman Pass but we did need to access the nearby Cherry Hill Rd, a 12 mile dirt road we'd use to get to the trailhead at Big Meadow. Sadly despite checking several times with the ranger it was still at least a few weeks away from opening.

Ok, no problem, I can always come up with a Plan B. So instead at the advice of Steve Eckert I switched us to use the Long Creek trailhead and come in from the east of Rockhouse.



(L is Big Meadow, the original car camp location. J is Long Creek Trailhead, the Plan B trailhead. H is the South Fork of the Kern. B is Rockhouse)

After the usually rash of last minute cancelations I was left with a strong group of 5. Besides my coleader Greg Mason we had Jen Blackie, Amin Faraday, and Jack Kieffer along for the fun.

Jack, Jen, and I left Buena Park around 9:10 pm and pulled into the Chimney Creek Campground a bit before 1 am. It's a great little campground, free except for requested donations, and has primitive facilities as long as you don't mind the disturbing number of spiders running around in the toilet opening.



The next morning I cheerfully kicked everyone out of their bags at 5 and we made the drive out to the Long Creek trailhead.

We found Greg and Amin waiting having arrived a bit earlier than us the night before. Surprisingly there were two other trucks parked there also.





We took care of the paperwork and soon started down the gated dirt road that led to the South Fork of the Kern.



Rockhouse Peak is the highpoint visible in the distance. The green trees below are the approximate location of the river.

We noticed paired tracks going down the road and guessed it must be rafters either putting in or taking out and using some sort of cart.

As we approached the river and I didn't see a giant overflowing mass of water wiping away everything in its path (the ranger I spoke to at the Isabella office may have slightly overstated the flooding situation) I started to hope we'd cross easily and maybe push on to the much further in Siretta Peak.



Ok, on second thought that is a bit high.

After wading in and verifying the water was over shoulder depth and moving quite fast we headed to the north looking for possible crossings.



We ran into a group of fisherman who looked as us like we were a bunch of madmen when I said we were looking to cross the river.

It became increasingly apparent we weren't going to find an easy crossing. Each spot we waded out ended up dropping quickly past shoulder depth.

Finally I picked a spot and decided to try swimming. I figured if I could make it across we could break down our packs and transfer things over one armload at a time.



That did work and I was soon waving to the group from the far side. Unfortunately we had full overnight packs to get across.



Jen tried it right after me and it became apparent any attempt where we didn't have full use of both arms for swimming would be rather unworkable.

We swung back to the south past the original point where we met the river. Despite following a few promising leads past muck and waist deep water each time we found ourselves faced with a deep fast moving channel. We even followed some rather large bear tracks for a bit but soon decided he swam for it also.

So that left us eating lunch around noon at a rather nice spot not far from where we started.

We'd already discussed that worst case we'd just spend the night on that side of the river and hike out the following day. I wasn't quite content with that and started trying to loop the rope over a log lodged in the reed directly across the deep swift moving part of the river.

Greg soon joined in but it was apparent our lasso technique needed work. So I did the logical thing and flung myself into the river again and swam across. A bit of work but I was soon clinging to the reeds at the far side of the channel.

I trudged through waist deep water and muck to verify that we could in fact make it to the far side from there.

I returned and made my way to the log I'd eyed from the other side. This did involve leaving the forest of reeds and crossing about 8 feet of swiftly flowing water before I could latch on to the log. Fortunately there were some underwater reeds I was able to employ as badly needed handholds.

Seeing me standing there my compatriots on the other side questioned how stable the log was. In the interest of science I proceeded to jump up and down and rock from side to side but failed to send the entire edifice plunging downstream.

I had brought along two 8 mm x 30m ropes and Greg proceeded to toss the first one over to me. Catching the end without plunging off the now wet and slightly unstable log proved to be a challenge.

We used the first rope to set a fixed line between a tree on the shore and one branch of the log. We then took the second rope, tied it off on each side, then clipped two small biners through bites and clipped them to the first rope.



(Picture from the trip back across which is why it's darker)

We now had a system to get the gear across.



We used the biners to attach packs and boots to the line and transfer them over to the log doing our best to keep the lines up out of the water. Of course that meant everyone still needed to swim...

I offered useful advice from my somewhat stable log perch. "Swim like hell and don't stop till you hit the reeds!"



Once gear was on the log we still had a good distance of water to cross including that fast moving section. Fortunately Jack was there to stand in the middle of the fast moving freezing cold water and hand packs back and forth



Smiles say FUN!



Once everything was handed over and transferred to a semi dry location we were able to grab everything and set off for the far shore.

Greg neglected to get wet so Jack filled in as my sweep and set off for Rockhouse.



We had a bit of wading through water up to our butts and then crossing a large shallow section of the river.



Reaching the other side we were able to switch back to our boots and slowly dry off.





Easy squeeze. Soon only slightly soggy we set off up the slope towards Rockhouse.

“Here’s the plan, just head UP!”



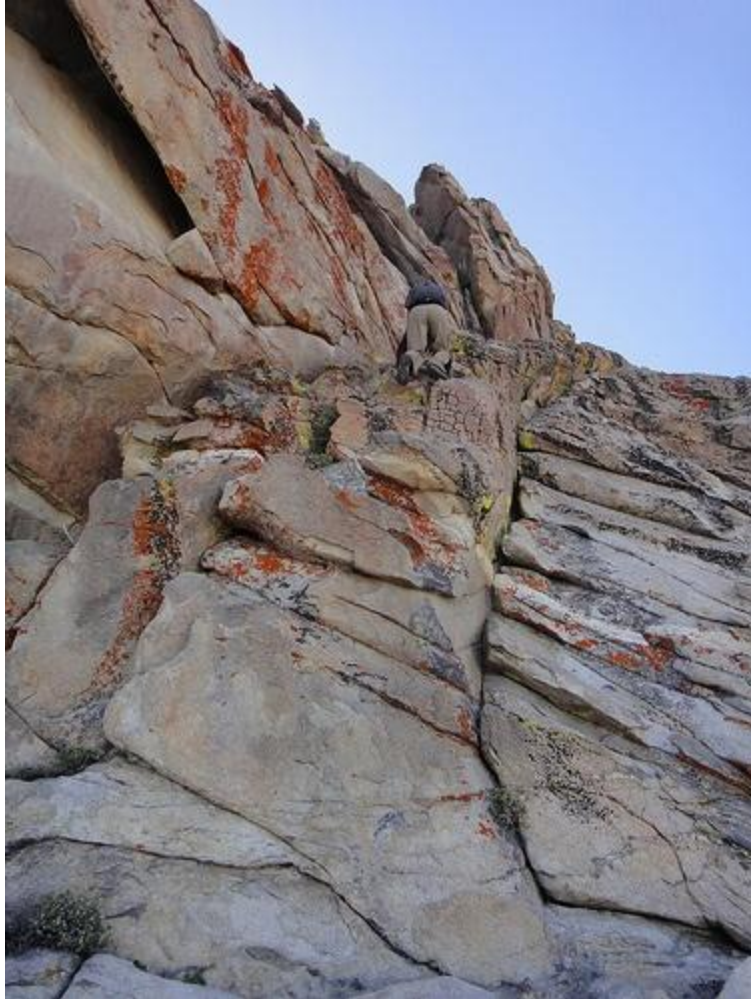
Instead of heading southwest to the standard route from Rockhouse saddle we climbed the north east ridge directly and followed it about a mile and a half to the summit.





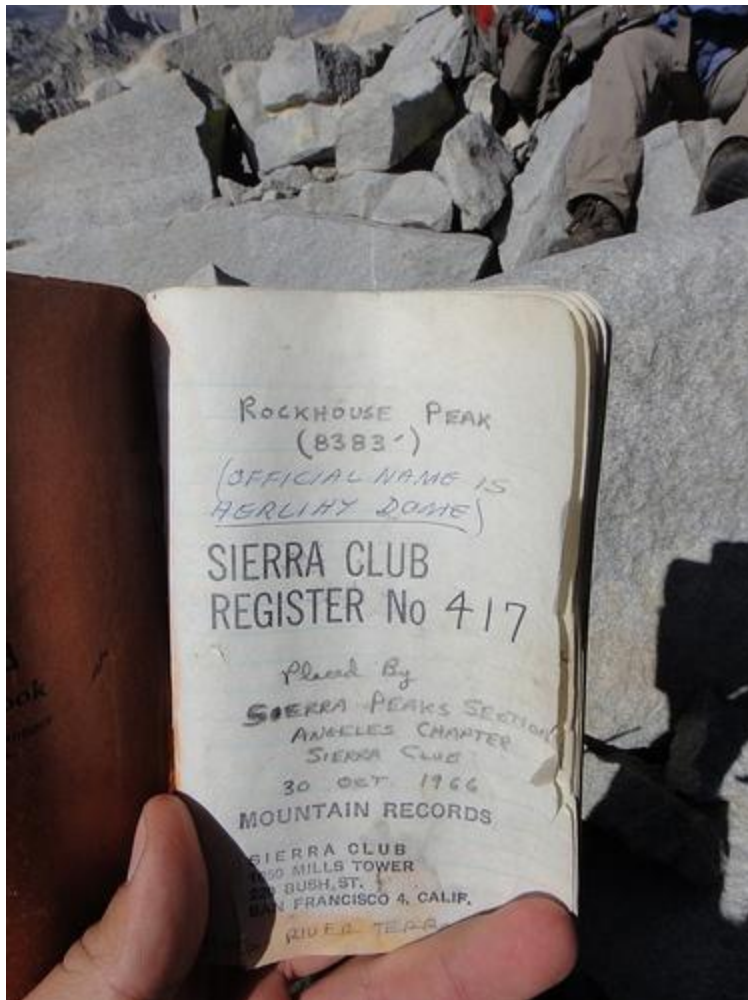
Once we made the ridge we were moving somewhat faster but it seemed like a surprisingly long time until we approached the summit itself.



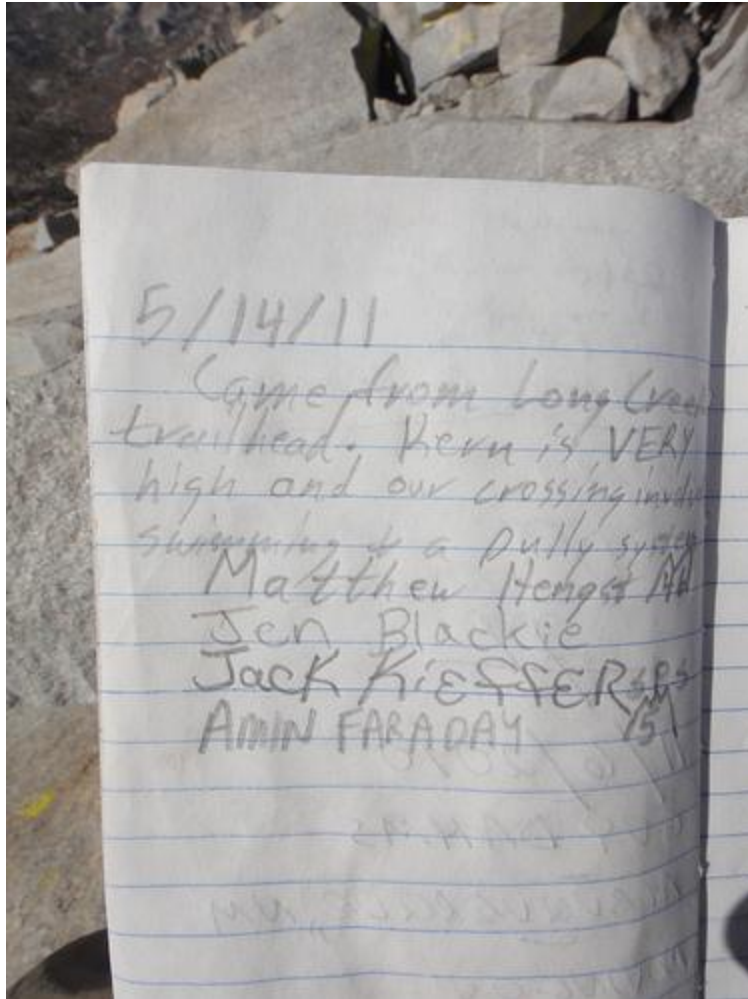


The climb itself wasn't bad. Some light class 3





There were 3 registers, 2 with writing, and the old one dated back to 1966. Not bad.



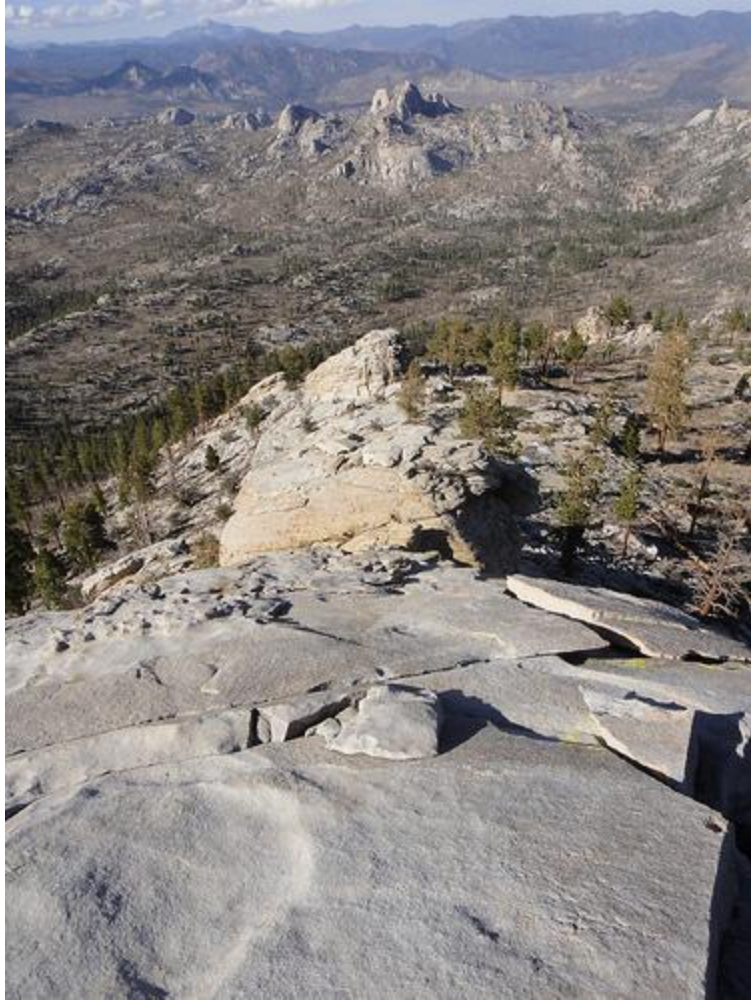
Our mark on the permanent record.



From the top we had a good view further into the Domelands towards where we were originally planned to camp. I didn't pick out Big Meadow but I could see Taylor Dome quite clearly and several bumps that looked like they'd be interesting to climb.



We were running out of daylight and still had to cross back over the river so we quickly headed back down.







We dropped down towards Rockhouse saddle hoping to join the Mahnter trail marked on the map for faster going. There wasn't much of a trail or an improvement.





Hey! One trail duck! Obviously we're on a trail.

As we approached the crossing we could see the campfire Greg had started but no sign of Greg. As it was his birthday we did the logical thing and broke into a boisterous rendition of happy birthday at the top of our lungs.

He soon appeared.

Back at the crossing we removed our boots and waded back to my old friend the slightly unstable log in strong current.



It was slightly chilly.



After the others quickly passed the gear out to me Jen and Amin went swimming for the far side and Jack joined me on the log.



“Swim like hell, don’t stop!”

We quickly clipped items onto the rope and Greg pulled them back across. Then it was our turn to go for a dip.

The water temperature actually didn’t bother you once you were in. At that point you were so focused on fighting the current it was the last thing on your mind.

And on the other side we had a fire waiting. It was quite nice considering we’d lost the sun at this point.



We dried off and slowly changed into warmer dryer items.



We stayed up around the fire until almost 11 pm.

The weather forecast called for a 50% change of precipitation with snow level reaching down past where we were. I'd already woken up once recently with my sleeping bag and face covered in snow so I reluctantly decided to break out the Tarp Tent.

Sometime that night it did start coming down. It didn't last for long but it was enough to wake up Jack (who had tried to sleep out) who then woke up Jen (who generally responds to anything but the softest wakeup with a scream) at which point I stumbled out to grab my boots which were drying on a nearby rock.

Jen being Jen she just propped herself up on a rock under an overhand and went back to sleep.

We had a slow wakeup the following morning and enjoyed the fire for a little bit longer.



We had a bit more snow slush come down.



No one except Jen was willing to swim back across the Kern with me for a shot at Taylor so we called it there and packed up. We'd managed to get the deepest in peak leaving Taylor and Siretta to be dayhiked from Big Meadow at some point.









We finally solved the mystery of the tracks we'd seen hiking in. None of us had guessed it was actually a radio flyer wagon they were pulling along filled with beer.





We also ran into this little guy. I hadn't seen one of them since visiting my grandparents in Texas as a child.



We made it out without major mishap and somewhat reluctantly started the drive home.



We actually made it home at a decent hour. For once. Fortunately I'd make up for it the following weekend.